Seeing Hashem in the ordinary

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

מי שאמר לשמן וידלוק

The One who told oil to burn...

Taanit 25a, opening words of Rabbi Chanina's response | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Gemara tells a story about Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa and his daughter. Before Shabbat, she was upset: she had mistakenly used vinegar in her lamp instead of oil. Her father reassured her that the One who makes oil burn could also make vinegar burn. The Gemara reports that the lamp continued burning through Shabbat, until they used its flame for Havdalah. This is a Shabbat story, not a Chanukah event. It invites us to notice Hashem's gifts in ordinary life as well as in miracles.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Chanukah lights are for the mitzvah, not for lighting our reading or other tasks. Use normal room lighting to read this sheet. The shamash is separate from the mitzvah lights. The story is not an experiment: do not try burning vinegar or changing a lamp's fuel.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Each partner names one everyday gift they sometimes overlook. Explain what life would be like without it. Then thank Hashem in your own words for one of those gifts.

Younger learners: Name something your body can do that you are thankful for.
Older learners: If ordinary nature comes from Hashem, what makes an unusual miracle especially noticeable?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Did Rabbi Chanina's daughter mistakenly use vinegar or water? 2. May we use the mitzvah lights as our reading light?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Reread Rabbi Chanina's response in Taanit 25a. Separate the event the Gemara reports from the lesson we draw. Does gratitude for Hashem's help remove our responsibility to prepare carefully? Explain.

Sources: Taanit 25a, opening words of Rabbi Chanina's response; Use of light: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Taanit 25a | Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa and his daughter

Complete story passage; a Shabbat event, not a Chanukah event

חד בי שמשי חזייה לברתיה דהוות עציבא אמר לה בתי למאי עציבת אמרה ליה כלי של חומץ נתחלף לי בכלי של שמן והדלקתי ממנו אור לשבת אמר לה בתי מאי איכפת לך מי שאמר לשמן וידלוק הוא יאמר לחומץ וידלוק תנא היה דולק והולך כל היום כולו עד שהביאו ממנו אור להבדלה

One Friday evening, he saw that his daughter was sad. He asked, "My daughter, why are you sad?" She answered, "I confused a container of vinegar with a container of oil, and lit the Shabbat lamp from it." He said, "My daughter, why should that trouble you? The One who told oil to burn will tell vinegar to burn." It was taught: It continued burning throughout the day, until they took a flame from it for Havdalah.

2. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1 | Using the light

Selected passage

לפי שאסור להשתמש בנר חנוכה בין בשבת בין בחול ואפילו לבדוק מעות או למנותן לאורה אסור ואפילו תשמיש של קדושה כגון ללמוד לאורה אסור ויש מי שמתיר בתשמיש של קדושה.

It is forbidden to use the Chanukah light, whether on Shabbat or a weekday. Even inspecting or counting coins by its light is forbidden. Even a sacred use, such as studying by its light, is forbidden; there is an opinion that permits a sacred use.

3. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1 | The additional lamp

Selected passage

ונוהגים להדליק נר נוסף כדי שאם ישתמש לאורה יהיה לאור הנוסף שהוא אותו שהודלק אחרון ויניחנו מרחוק קצת משאר נרות מצוה.

The custom is to light an additional lamp, so that if one uses the light, it will be the light of that additional lamp, which was lit last. One places it a little apart from the other mitzvah lamps.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Our practice is to use normal room light for study, as on the front. The source records another opinion; its presence is a chance to notice how halachic texts preserve discussion. This miracle story is not an instruction to experiment with fire.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.